

FRANCE, HISTORY OF



THE LARGEST COUNTRY in western Europe, France has dominated European history ever since the Franks conquered the country in the 5th century. Its vast natural wealth and large population have enabled a

succession of rulers, such as Charlemagne in the 9th century, Louis XIV in the 17th, and Napoleon in the 19th, to create powerful empires that spanned Europe. Despite three bitter wars with Germany between 1870 and 1945, France emerged as one of the world's superpowers. Today, France is a leading member of the European Union, and one of the wealthiest countries in the world.

Medieval France

In common with other European rulers, the power of the French kings was always limited by the strength of local nobles. Despite this weakness, France became one of the richest countries in Europe during the 11th century. Major trade fairs in the Champagne region attracted merchants from all over Europe, and trade and commerce flourished.



Angevin Empire

As a result of marriage and war, Henry II of England (r.1154–89) ruled much of western and northern France. His vast realm was called the Angevin Empire, after the county of Anjou. For years it was a threat to French unification.

Château Gaillard, an Angevin castle

Bourbons

Under the Bourbon kings, France emerged as the major power in Europe during the 17th century. Habsburg-ruled Spain and Austria – enemies of France – were defeated, and all power was centralized under the king. Industry and commerce were supported, and France established colonies in North America and India.



Palace of Versailles

In order to increase his own power, and reduce that of the nobility, Louis XIV built this vast new palace outside Paris. Some 36,000 people worked on the building, decorating it with the best examples of French art and design. At the centre was the king's bed chamber, where Louis received guests.

Samian ware bowl



French potters made this type of ware in the Roman period.



Religious wars

The Reformation split France, with many Catholics becoming Huguenots (Protestants). In 1562, civil war broke out between the two sides; religious toleration was agreed by the Edict of Nantes in 1598, but tension remained high. In 1685, Louis XIV revoked the Edict, and many Huguenots fled to England and Holland.



Hand-painted figures

Gilded decoration

Sèvres porcelain vase



Horses heads, carved c.10,000 BC

Prehistoric France

The first inhabitants of France were prolific artists. More than 20,000 years ago, they adorned caves at Lascaux and elsewhere with lifelike pictures of animals. They also carved likenesses of animal heads from bone, antler, and rock.

Roman France

Between 58 and 51 BC, a Roman army led by Julius Caesar conquered France. The new province of Gaul was one of the richest in the empire. Trade flourished, and the Romans built many roads and bridges. They also introduced growing grapes for wine.

Franks

In 486, the Franks from Germany routed the last Roman governor of Gaul and took control, giving France its name. At first the Franks continued with Roman customs, but their empire broke up in civil wars. The 8th-century kings Charles Martel, Pepin the Short, and Charlemagne restored order.



Charlemagne

Renaissance France

Joan of Arc, who fought the English for independence, was burnt at the stake in 1431. During the 15th century, the French kings drove out the English, and united their country. They also crushed the power of the nobles. During the next century, the ideas of the Italian Renaissance entered France. New châteaux were built, and the arts flourished.

Golden age

The 17th and 18th centuries were a golden age of the arts. Royal support led to the founding of the Gobelins tapestry works in 1602 and the royal pottery at Sèvres in 1756. The nobility supported artists such as Watteau and Fragonard, dramatists such as Racine, Molière and Corneille, the writer Montaigne, creator of the essay, and the fable-writer La Fontaine.

Louis XIV

During the long reign of Louis XIV (r.1643–1715), the power of the French kings reached its height. Louis believed in the divine right of kings to rule, and governed without parliament. He reorganized the army and expanded French territory. But his lavish lifestyle left France almost bankrupt.

